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Johannesburg

For other places with the same name, see [Johannesburg \(disambiguation\)](#).

Johannesburg (also *Jo'burg*, *Egoli* or *Jozi*) is a large metropolis and [South Africa's](#) largest city. Once regarded as South Africa's crime capital in the turbulent nineties, the city has shaken off that reputation led by its youthful exuberant population and a growing black middle class, not to mention the omnipresent soundtrack of Amapiano and house music.

With a wealth of historic sights and neighbourhoods to explore, there's enough to fill a visit of days, weeks, or even months before getting a true feel for the city. Jo'burg is a city on the move where the most ambitious of South Africans (and Africans more broadly) come to seek opportunity in the big city.

Districts

Inner City

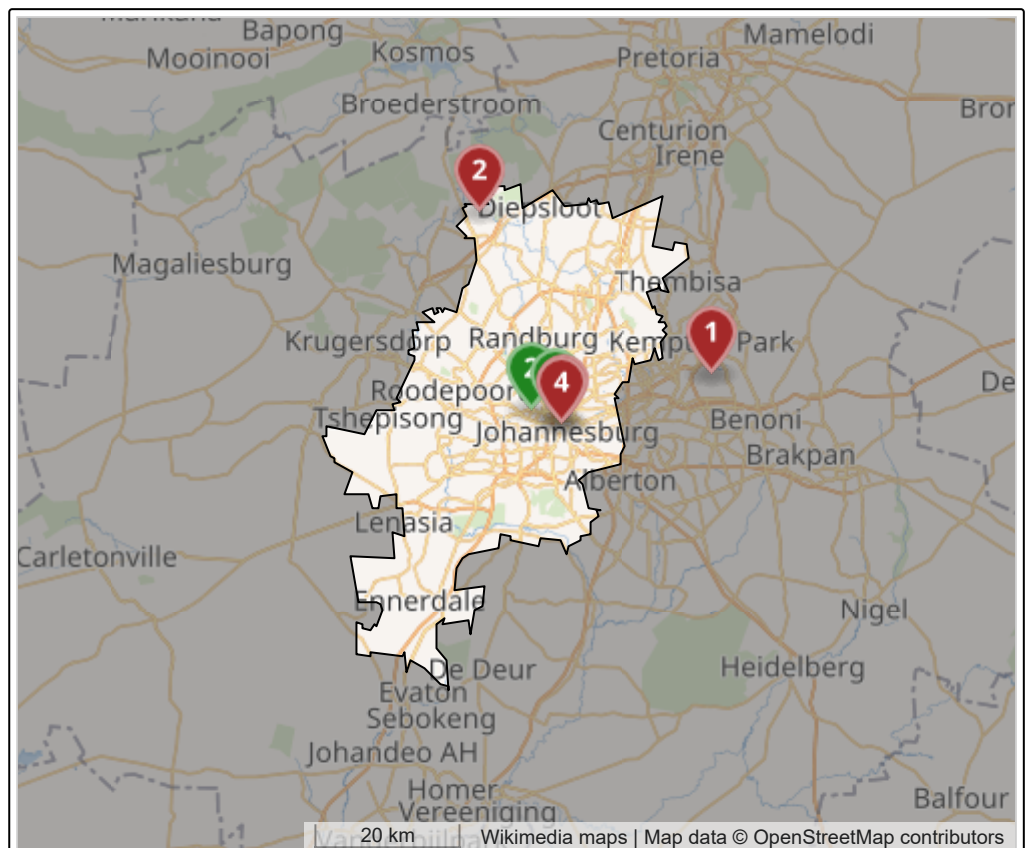
the central districts of Johannesburg, including the tourist areas of Braamfontein, Maboneng, Newtown and Fordsburg

Sandton

including Rosebank, Randburg, and other northern suburbs

Soweto

built as a dormitory town for Black Africans who worked in white houses, factories,



Map of Johannesburg

and industries, parts of Soweto are now home to the growing Black middle class

South Johannesburg

Alberton, Rosettenville, Brackendowns and Turfontein

Johannesburg is split into eight administrative regions. These exclude the city of Ekurhuleni which traditionally was considered part of Johannesburg but has been split for administrative purposes. Although this list is not exhaustive, the main areas in Joburg are:

- Inner City (which encompasses the tourist areas of Braamfontein, Maboneng, Newtown and Fordsburg)
- Old Joburg (which encompasses Melville, Greenside, Killarney, Emmarentia, Parktown, Houghton and others)
- Sandton (the new city centre including Rivonia, Fourways and Sunninghill)
- Randburg (which encompasses Northcliff, Linden, Weltevreden Park, Bordeaux, Greymont)
- Soweto — home of the Nelson Mandela National Museum
- Alexandra
- Midrand (which encompasses Waterfall City and Kyalami)
- Roodepoort (the West, which encompasses the Cradle of Humankind, Muldersdrift and Lanseria Airport)
- South Johannesburg — Alberton, Rosettenville, Brackendowns, Turfontein, etc.

Understand

Johannesburg has a population of about 5.6 million people in the urban area (2023), half of whom live in Soweto and adjacent suburbs. Three quarters of the population is formed by South Africa's black residents who mostly live in Soweto, while white residents amount to about 12% (2019). The remaining 11% are of other descent, including Africa's largest ethnic Chinese community. The city is home to two Chinatowns; the original one on Commissioner Street has shrunk dramatically since its heyday, but still has a few shops and business run by the small community of South African Chinese, while a newer and larger Chinatown in the suburb of Cyrildene is largely populated by immigrants and expatriates from China. Unlike other South African cities, no language group dominates, although English is the established lingua franca.

The city is the economic hub of South Africa, and to some extent, the rest of Africa. Yet the city's wealth is unequally distributed among its inhabitants, causing the city to have living conditions varying from first world to third world conditions. The contrast between rich and poor has led to one of the highest crime rates in the world. The more affluent tend to live in houses with high security by western standards, whilst the less affluent live in less desirable housing conditions. That said, crime rarely deters from daily life, especially for visitors who have little reason to visit the city's rough areas. Many South Africans choose to live here over other, safer parts of the country.

There are many things that are unique to Johannesburg. It features a distinct street entrepreneurship, and motorists can buy things from vendors selling goods at traffic lights, as in many other developing-world cities. This includes food, umbrellas, soccer balls, cellular phone accessories and many other goods. Barber shops consisting of nothing but a chair and an enthusiastic barber can be found on the sides of roads, although they tend to specialize in African rather than Caucasian hair. Mine dumps can also be seen throughout the city and are a reminder of the city's legacy of gold mining. These dumps are fast disappearing as new gold extraction techniques have made it profitable for mining companies to reprocess them.

With around 6 million trees, Johannesburg is most likely the world's largest man-made urban forest. The city is certainly one of the greenest in the world, considering that the natural landscape is savannah.

Climate

The weather is generally regarded as excellent; temperatures reach the mid-30s Celsius (95°F) in the summer months (Dec-Feb) with little to no wind and with occasional, spectacular afternoon thunderstorms. Temperatures in winter can drop below freezing but snow is extremely rare. The city is at an altitude of 1750 metres above sea level so newcomers can easily get out of breath.

Tourist information

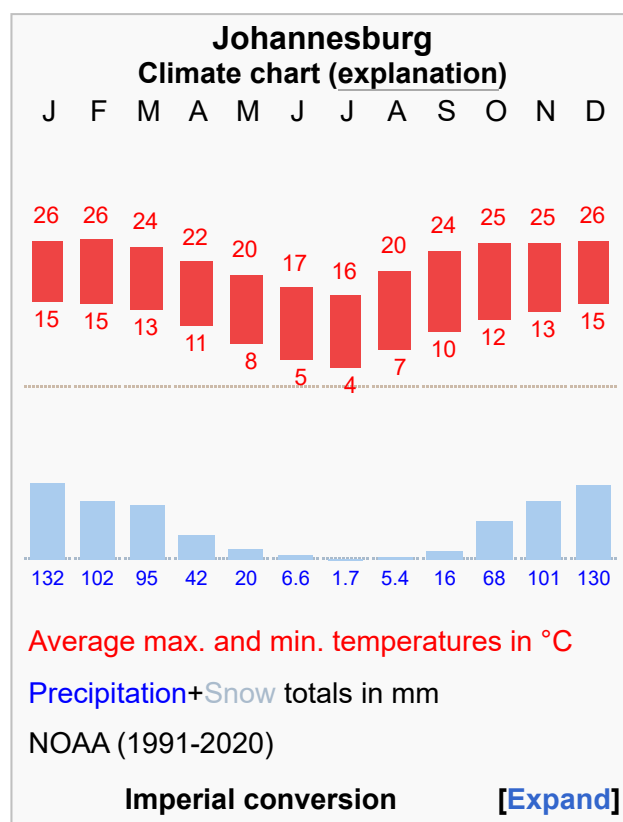
- Explore Johannesburg (<https://www.gauteng.net/visit/explore/johannesburg/>) website

Orientation

By far the easiest way to find your bearings in Johannesburg is by finding the two telecommunication towers on the horizon. The Hillbrow tower is located near the city centre while the Brixton tower (*also called the Sentech tower*) is located out to the west of the city. Since they are both tall towers located on high ground and easily distinguishable from other structures and each other, they make excellent landmarks.

- If the Hillbrow tower is to the left of the Brixton tower, then you are in the north
- If the Hillbrow tower is closer than the Brixton tower, then you are in the east
- If the Brixton tower is to the left of the Hillbrow tower, then you are in the south
- If the Brixton tower is closer than the Hillbrow tower, then you are in the west

Depending on your location, you may also see a cylindrical building (*Ponte City Apartments*) located close to the Hillbrow tower.



There is a *ring road* system of freeways, with the city centre located at the centre of the ring. The ring is formed by the N1 on the north and west, the N3 on the east and the N12 on the south. The ring is dissected north/south by the M1 freeway and partially dissected east/west by the M2 freeway.

Get in

By car

A number of highways from everywhere in South Africa go to Johannesburg, the *N1* from Cape Town and Bloemfontein or the *N3* from Durban making it an easy to reach destination, including:

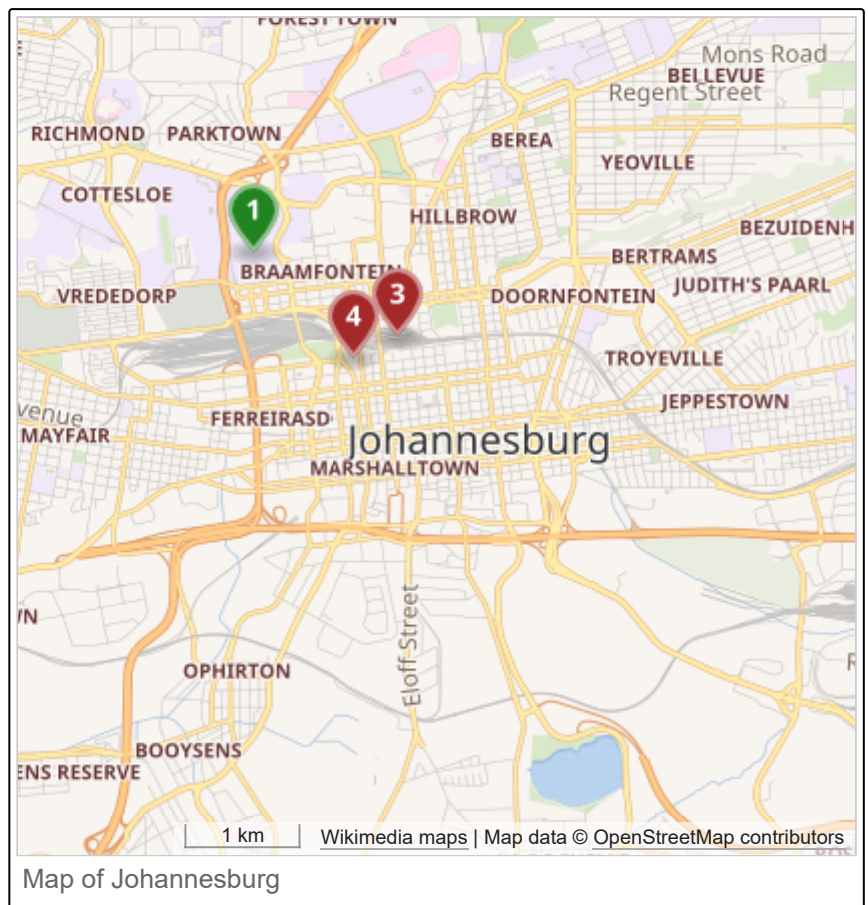
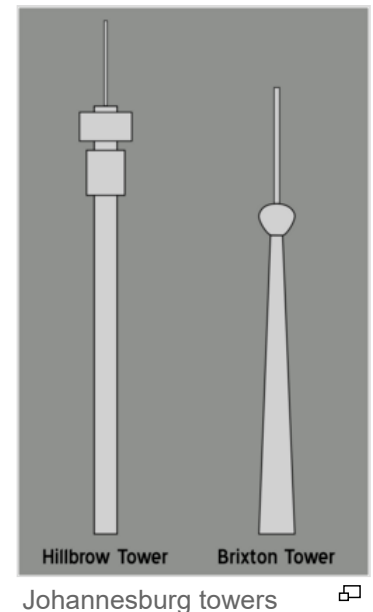
- N1 from Cape Town and Harare in Zimbabwe
- N3 from Durban
- N4 from Mbombela and the Kruger National Park, as well as Botswana
- N12 from Kimberley and Potchefstroom
- N14 from Upington and Namibia

Traffic can be particularly bad during peak hours (M-F 06:30–09:00 and 15:30–18:30) so plan your journey accordingly. Accidents are frequent and can cause delays at any time of the day and night. Take extra care if you are taking a car to OR Tambo airport as accidents are frequent on at the Gillooly's Interchange and on the R24 towards the airport.

Traffic has been getting worse, and traffic jams may delay your journey. As the city is large and spread out, getting around may require covering large distances e.g. from Midrand to Soweto is over 45 km (28 mi).

By plane

- **1 O.R. Tambo International Airport (JNB^{IATA})** (formerly called Johannesburg International and before that Jan Smuts Airport, these old names are still commonly used), ☎ +27 11 921-6911. The main airport for Johannesburg. It is the busiest airport in Africa and is the connecting hub for flights to other cities in Southern Africa. There are many flights to



Johannesburg from international hubs, especially London. Most flights from Europe are overnight and arrive in the early morning. If you arrive on one of these flights be prepared for very long waits at immigration. Remember your yellow fever certificate if you are flying from a high risk area. (updated Mar 2018 |)

Terminal A is for international flights, and B domestic. When flying out some international flights may have their check-in in Terminal B, but will still leave from Terminal A. The two terminals are adjacent to each other and a 5-minute indoor walk apart.

The airport is 24 km (15 mi) east from the city centre. There is a highspeed train to Sandton and Pretoria (see below) from the airport. If you are taking a taxi, keep walking straight until you exit the building and then turn left until you see a long line of taxis (mainly Mercedes) with yellow taxi signs on their roof. These are licensed taxis with meters (tell the driver the address and insist on using the meter before you get in the car). Do *not* go with anyone who approaches you offering a taxi while you are inside the airport building, these are unlicensed touts, and you'll end up paying more. If you are staying in a hotel, try to get the hotel to send a shuttle to pick you up.

For getting money try to avoid the many banks and money changers on the left of the arrivals door: They display the exchange rates but don't indicate their excessive "commissions" that can reduce what you actually get by 10% or more — this is the case at all banks and bureaux de change in South Africa. Better to use the ATMs to withdraw cash. The ATMs are located one floor higher up in the airport, in the retail mall where there are many shops and restaurants.

- **2 Lanseria International Airport (<http://www.lanseria.co.za>) (HLA ^{IATA})**. Johannesburg's other airport that caters for passengers on commercial airlines. It is privately owned unlike O.R. Tambo which is run by the Airports Company South Africa (ACSA). Situated northwest of Johannesburg, it is reachable from the Sandton, Pretoria, Westrand and Midrand regions, but can be traffic hell to get there. Fewer airlines fly to this airport and it is mostly used for regional, corporate and diplomatic passage. (updated Dec 2020 |)

The airport is mainly for smaller charter, cargo and classic airline flights; it is in fact busier than Johannesburg International and sees more air traffic.

For more information see [Discount airlines in Africa](#).

- **Rand Airport (<http://www.randairport.co.za/>) (QRA ^{IATA})** is primarily a business and general aviation airport.
- **Grand Central Airport (<http://www.grandcentral.co.za/>) (GCJ ^{IATA})** - Located just off the N1 between Johannesburg and [Pretoria](#) this airport is primarily a business and general aviation airport.

By train

Johannesburg is South Africa's hub for rail travel. While the national network is rather small, there are extensive rail services from nearby cities within the [Gauteng](#) region.

Shosholozameyl (<https://www.shosholozameyl.co.za/scheduledtrains.html>) is the national passenger rail service. As of November 2025, Shosholozameyl only operates on route two routes: Johannesburg – Bloemfontein – Queenstown – East London & Johannesburg – Durban. However, trains are really rare and departures occur a few times a year. Check their website for more information. If you are lucky, maybe you will find a train.

Gautrain (<http://gautrain.co.za>) is the new high-speed train between Johannesburg, Pretoria and OR Tambo airport. A fantastic, first-world-quality train service takes just 15 minutes from airport to Sandton. From Marlboro or Sandton stations you can connect to Pretoria or Park station. It's very secure: there are lots of cameras and guards on the trains and platforms. Fares are reasonable, except if going to or from the airport, where, depending on the destination, an additional R155 to R185 (2025) is slapped on the fare. Gautrain to and from OR Tambo airport is often more expensive than taking Bolt or Uber, especially if you are traveling with others. Don't try to walk to the nearby Rhodesfield Gautrain station to avoid this surcharge; it's dangerous and a gauntlet of freeways and flyovers. There is also an additional once off fee of R21 (2025) for a Gautrain Card, unless you use a contactless bank card or credit card.

MetroRail (<http://www.metrorail.co.za>) operates frequent commuter trains to many suburbs and outlying towns. As Metrorail operates services in several separate cities, for operational purposes it is subdivided into five regions. The Witwatersrand region is the region that covers the greater Johannesburg Metropolitan area. Trains run from Johannesburg and Germiston outwards to Springs, Pretoria, Soweto and Krugersdorp. Metrorail is much cheaper than Gautrain but not as safe; as a tourist you should choose the more expensive Gautrain option.

- **3 Johannesburg Park Station**, Rissik Street. The central station and is in the city centre between Rissik (west), Wolmarans (north), Wanderers (east) and De Villiers (south) streets, it occupies several blocks. Whilst the station itself is quite safe, the areas around it may not be. Try to organise onward transport prior to arrival, even if it's just a short walk from the station. It's best to ask local people about any other public transport before you use it. Gautrain has a station located nearby, it's connected with Park Station via an underground station. As usual with Gautrain, security (cameras and guards) are plentiful. (updated Oct 2018 |)

By bus

Long-distance buses arrive at **Park Station** or at the new **Johannesburg International Transport Interchange**, located a few blocks west of Park station. All major bus companies provide a service to and from Johannesburg. A few of these include:

- Greyhound (<http://www.greyhound.co.za>) the bus service is offering services to destinations all over South Africa.
- Intercape (<https://www.intercape.co.za>), a major carrier in Southern Africa with routes from most major cities within SA and neighboring countries.
- Translux (<http://www.translux.co.za>), their route network extends to many South African destinations and major cities in Malawi, Mozambique, Zambia and Zimbabwe.
- Magic Bus (<http://www.magicbus.co.za>), Focuses on short distance transportation, i.e. scheduled airport shuttling.
- S.A Roadlink (<http://www.saroadlink.co.za>) has coaches travelling to and from major major city centers in South Africa.
- The Baz Bus (<http://www.bazbus.com>) offers a hop-on, hop-off service aimed at backpackers. It runs from Johannesburg to Durban via the Drakensberg, and then continues along South Africa's coast to Cape Town.
- Eldo Coaches have buses from Johannesburg to East London for R300. and Johannesburg to Cape town from R450.
- Eagle Liner have buses from Johannesburg to Bulawayo Zimbabwe for R330.
- **4 Johannesburg International Transport Interchange**, 66 Harrison St. (updated Jun 2022 |)

Get around

Johannesburg was a city built for the car and so public transport is in the development process. The Gautrain (a speed train not part of the metro system) is a good, clean and safe way to jump fast between the airport, Malboro, Midrand, Rosebank, Pretoria and Centurion. There are buses and minicabs on the streets, but there tends to be no designated stops, so buses may be flagged down on main roads such as Oxford street and Jan Smuts. They can be unsafe, but larger double decker metro bus are easy to use all along Oxford, starting in Gandhi Square, going through Killarney, Rosebank, Illovo, Sandton, Rivonia and Sunninghill (bus no. 5C and 5D). Generally, it is a bad idea to make use of minibus taxis unless accompanied by locals. The other bus alternatives, are orange putco buses, coming more regularly than the metro buses and it's slightly more expensive. Lastly there are the Gautrain feeder buses connected to the Gautrain, these have quite extensive routes from each station - these can be found easily on the gautrain website or mobi site. The problem is that buses are quite problematic on weekends and public holidays, Gautrain buses do not run, Metro buses have two route runs, and putco buses are at a complete halt. This is when the train would be a good alternative, or rent a car.

Renting a car will give you the best flexibility and opportunity to tour the city, however driving is fast paced, but by no means difficult as long as you stay alert. Heavy traffic into Sandton in the morning (06:30 to 09:00) from all directions leading towards Sandton and in the afternoon all routes leading out of Sandton (15:30 to 18:30) in all directions could delay your journey by up to 2 hours, so plan accordingly.

Car rental

Renting a car is your best option if you are a confident driver, as the city's public transport is very, very limited. It is worth buying a good road map of Johannesburg, using a GPS (available when you rent a car) and planning your trips carefully before setting out. The city is large and somewhat poorly signposted. Make sure to be exceptionally clear with your rental agency what types of things are covered by their insurance plans. The phrase "full coverage" doesn't necessarily mean full coverage. Traffic can be aggressive, and minibus taxis in particular often defy the rules of the road.

Like any big city, there are some areas of Johannesburg that you don't want to stray into if you look like a tourist or don't have enough fuel to get out of. Many areas have high rates of violent crime, and carjacking is a real risk; it is therefore often advised that you should not stop at traffic lights after dark. Ask advice. Local numberplates start with "GP" (Gauteng Province). If your car has any other numberplate, then you will advertise yourself as being from "out-of-area". If in doubt, stop at a police station and ask them for directions.

From the airport: stay on the freeway between the airport and Sandton, and don't divert through the townships and Alexandra on London Road. A GPS following the fastest route will usually divert around the townships, but it pays to know where you are going. (If you are coming from the airport and you are afraid of getting this wrong, carry on past Marlboro Drive with the N3 (which becomes the N1) until you reach Rivonia road. Then turn left/south and this will take you straight into Sandton, bypassing any townships.)

- **Europcar Car Hire** (<http://www.europcar.co.za>), ☎ +27 11 883-4352, info@europcar.co.za (<mailto:info@europcar.co.za>). Car rentals in Johannesburg and Johannesburg Airport.
- **Pace Car Rental** (<http://www.pacecarrental.co.za>), ☎ +27 11 262-5500, info@pacecarrental.co.za.co.za (<mailto:info@pacecarrental.co.za.co.za>). Long-term car rental in Johannesburg and Sandton; cars, bakkies and minibuses.
- **Rent a Wreck** (<http://rentawreck.co.za>), ☎ +27 11 402-5150, info@rentawreck.co.za (<mailto:info@rentawreck.co.za>). Very cheap car rental. The cars are old but are reliable.
- **Exeque Car Rental** (<http://www.exequecarrental.co.za>), ☎ +27 10 235-0898, info@exequecarrental.co.za (<mailto:info@exequecarrental.co.za>). Long-term rentals only.
- **Xtreme Car Rental** (<https://www.xtremecarrental.co.za/car-hire-branches/car-rental-johannesburg-car-hire-gauteng/cash-car-rental-johannesburg/>), 18 Herman Road, Meadowdale, ☎ +27 11 394-0771, info@xtremecarrental.co.za (<mailto:info@xtremecarrental.co.za>). 06:00-18:00. Cash car rental near Johannesburg Airport.

Parking (on the roadside) is often free in the sense that there is no meters, however there is often a local car guard that will keep an eye on your car for a few rand. Try to park in a well-lit space and always plan ahead, it's not a good idea to park far away from your destination. When available, use a secure parking area. All Gautrain stations have safe and secure parking, although a tad expensive.

By bus

Public transport in Johannesburg is provided by city buses and informal minibus services. Bus (other than Gautrain buses and the City Sightseeing ones) is *not* a viable option if you are a foreign tourist/business visitor unfamiliar with South Africa and Johannesburg in particular. Large blue city buses run up and down the main roads and mini buses can be flagged down on the side of the street although they are not the best mode of transport as they are unreliable and often associated with crime. These should not be used unless you are very familiar with the way of life in South Africa and the basic geography of Johannesburg.

- **Rea Vaya** (<http://www.reavaya.org.za/>). This bus rapid transit (BRT) is designed to offer a safe, secure and affordable public transport system on main routes to and from the city. Rea Vaya has dedicated bus lanes and stops every 500 m, with offboard fare collection and level boarding like a rail system. Smaller buses (feeders) and taxis will add value to transport people to and from the main routes.
- **Metrobus** (<http://www.mbus.co.za/>), ☎ +27 11 833-5538. Providing bus traffic in the Johannesburg region. Buses are available but routes and times are somewhat limited by western standards.
- **Minibus taxis**. should be avoided unless you are with a local: the routes are very confusing, and drivers will often say 'yes' when you ask 'are you going to X?' so that they get your money, and then drop you at some crossroads and say 'change here'. Thus if you travel with minibuses it's safer to ask directions from the other passengers, not the driver. People are generally very friendly and will help you out. Minibuses are frequently not roadworthy (although they are in much better condition than in most of the rest of Africa) and involved in fatal accidents. Extreme and violent competition between minibus taxi drivers has resulted in affordable transportation for the masses. (updated Dec 2016 |)
- **City Sightseeing** (<https://www.citysightseeing.co.za/johannesburg>), ☎ +27 861 733 287. While not really public transportation, the City Sightseeing bus tours some of the city's most prominent tourist attractions (Apartheid Museum, Constitution Hill, Braamfontein, etc.) and can therefore be used as an alternative to car and taxi. Tour starts at "The Zone" in Rosebank.

- **Gautrain** (<http://join.gautrain.co.za/Buses.aspx>), toll-free: 0800 428 87246. In addition to the train, Gautrain runs an extensive bus network that feeds passengers to the different Gautrain stations. The buses are safe and can be used by tourists, but as always, plan ahead and know where you are going. There is no weekend service. To use Gautrain services you need a reusable Gautrain Card (R21, 2025) but you can also use a contactless credit/debit card.

By taxi

Foreigners are advised to use only normal sedan taxis (metered or fixed-price taxis that transport only you and your travel partners), as minibus taxis have a reputation for being rather unsafe. The minibus taxis, however, are very cheap and are the quickest way between two points. It provides an authentic experience but if you are using these, you must understand the risks. Using these relies mostly on a variety of local hand signals, and should only ever be used if travelling with a local. Metered taxis are not as abundant as many big cities but are available and in most cases, need to be called before hand. This could incur long delays as you wait for the taxi. Unless you are visiting for a very short time, it would be worth your while to rent a car. Bolt and Uber, ride hailing apps, are also a viable alternative for getting around, although these companies is highly unpopular with local taxi companies, with reports of violence against both drivers and passengers.

In general all the taxi operators collude with one another and fix prices, so taxis are not cheap or metered. Hagglng is usual so it is best to agree a price when you phone. Do not rely on taxi ranks in shopping malls as often there are none. Always have a few taxi telephone numbers and cash with you so you avoid being stranded anywhere. If you have a local SIM, Uber offers better pricing and service than taxis.

- **Sandton Taxi Cabs (Pty) Ltd** (<http://www.sandtontaxicabs.co.za/>), ☎ +27 11 039-4402. Transport company offering chauffeur services, airport transfers, day tours & 24hrs taxi services.
- **Airport Link** (<http://www.airportlink.co.za/>), ☎ +27 11 792-2017. Fixed price airport transfer service.
- **Elias**, ☎ +27 76 834-0670. Friendly taxi driver based in the CBD.
- **Magicbus** (<http://www.magicbus.co.za/>), ☎ +27 11 548-0822. Offers shuttle services between OR Tambo Airport and Sandton. They also offer door-to-door transfers. A bit expensive for the single traveller but reasonable when travelling in groups.
- **Maxi Taxi** (<http://www.maxitaxisa.co.za/>), ☎ +27 11 648-1212. Reputable taxi firm based in Yeoville.
- **Roses Taxi**, ☎ +27 11 403-9625. Operates throughout the city.
- **Zebra Cabs**, ☎ +27 86 110-5105. Operates throughout Johannesburg. Every car is equipped with a GPS. R11/km.

Ride hailing apps

- **Bolt** (<https://www.bolt.eu/>)
- **Uber** (<http://www.uber.com>)

By train

Metrorail Gauteng runs an extensive commuter train network with stations in most districts, however trains are often crowded and has a reputation of being unsafe. The high-speed **Gautrain** (<https://www.gautrain.co.za/>) can be used for travel between the Inner city and Sandton.

See

Inner City

The poor reputation of the **Central Business District (CBD)** is no longer deserved. There are numerous galleries and art spaces popping up across the CBD. The city centre is the most-visited part of Johannesburg for African tourists, particularly the traders who come to shop at Johannesburg's wholesale outlets.

Newtown and the **Market Theatre area** (the city's cultural precinct) is now easily accessible from the highway and Mandela Bridge and very fun; here you will find live music venues and bars too.

Braamfontein, the university area, has a great Saturday market, lively night life, is very artsy. By day there's nothing here.

On the **east side** of the city, Main Street Life, Maboneng Precinct (<http://www.mabonengprecinct.com/>) and Arts on Main (especially the Sunday market (<https://m.facebook.com/MarketOnMain/>) and The Bioscope (<http://www.thebioscope.co.za/>) independent cinema). The Maboneng area has 24-hr security so you can freely walk around the streets, just be sure not to stray away too far. Troyeville has a fantastic restaurant at the Troyeville Hotel (<http://www.troyevillehotel.co.za/>), an art centre and all the main sport stadiums (football, tennis, athletics, rugby).

On the **west side**, Fordsburg is the formerly-Indian now known as “little Somalia” and “Eithiopia Town” part of central Joburg and has some Indian and Pakistani restaurants as well as African street food, shops and markets. Good food is to be found in this neighbourhood, which, by Johannesburg's standards, shows signs of street life in the evenings, and more so on Friday and Saturday. Most places are halal, and so no alcohol is served. The Oriental Plaza (<http://www.orientalplaza.co.za/>) shopping mall is here and has good bargains.

In the centre of town, between Jeppe St and Bree Street at Delvers Street, look up and see the Amharic script which denotes that you are in the Ethiopian/Somali part of town. There are Ethiopian restaurants and coffee shops in the Africa Mall and Johannesburg Mall. Best to arrive before 14:00.

Did you know?

At 222 m the Carlton Centre is the tallest building in Africa, but not the tallest structure. Both the Hillbrow (270 m) and Sentech (234 m) towers in Johannesburg are taller than the Carlton. The tallest structure in Africa is the 301-m SASOL chimney in Secunda followed closely by two 300-m smoke stacks at the Duvha Power Station outside Witbank.

To the north east, **Yeoville** is known as Le Petit Kinshasa and is home to many of the Francophone African diaspora in Johannesburg. Lots of Camerounian restaurants and Congolese bars.

Hillbrow has a bad reputation for drug dealing, sex bars, crime, etc., but is slowly improving. If you visit Constitution Hill, or Johannesburg Art Gallery, Hillbrow is right across the street, not that scary. Empty your pockets and go for a walk to the base of the Hillbrow Tower on a Sunday morning. Stay on the main streets and keep your wits about you, and don't carry anything that is worth stealing. It is certainly an interesting experience. Worth watching Louis Theroux's *Law and Disorder in Johannesburg* before your visit.

Points of interest

- The Top of Africa on the 50th floor of the Carlton Centre, gives you a panoramic view of the city from the top of Africa's tallest building.
- The Johannesburg Art Gallery is the biggest gallery on the African continent. It has a good collection of local and international work on display.
- Standard Bank Gallery is a corporate-owned gallery that hosts South African and international exhibitions.
- The Sci-Bono Discovery Centre offers dynamic learning experiences in maths, science and technology.
- Origins Centre has an excellent multimedia display of the rock art and the origins of humankind.
- WITS Anglo American Digital Dome, formerly Johannesburg Planetarium, uses high-resolution projectors and surround-sound technology create an immersive environment for educational experiences about the wonders of the universe and the richness of human creativity.
- Walter Sisulu Botanical Gardens in Roodepoort is one of the last green areas remaining within Johannesburg.
- Constitution Hill is the site of the notorious Old Fort prison complex. It is a fascinating place well worth a visit: part courtroom, part museum and part art gallery.
- The Workers Museum tells the story of Migrant Labourers who came to Johannesburg to find work. Having left their homes and families, black migrant workers faced slave-like conditions shown by the original dormitories, concrete bunks and punishment room at the old compound building.



Have a seat and relax at the Walter
Sisulu Botanical Gardens

Sandton and the northern suburbs

In the plush north, the suburbs of Greenside, Houghton, Parktown North, Parkhurst, Killarney, Rosebank, Illovo, Melrose North, Atholl, Sandown, Sandton, Morningside, Fourways and Randburg are green, leafy and pleasant, and safe and comforting to first-world visitors, most have large shopping malls of some description, and some have a walkable main street with cafes, boutiques and grocery shops.

The South African Lipizzaners in Sandton is the only place you will ever get to see performing Lipizzaners recognized by the Spanish Riding School, outside of Vienna.

The Montecasino Bird Gardens in Sandton is home to many birds and other small wildlife. Also look out for the 2500-year-old tree near the parrots.

The South African National Museum of Military History in Saxonwold has a good collection of military hardware, including one of the very few ME 262 jet fighters from World War II still in existence. There is also a huge South African-built G6 self-propelled, 155mm howitzer on show.

The Sophiatown Heritage & Cultural Centre tells the story of a thriving multi-racial neighbourhood that was razed in 1955 to create a new whites-only town.

South Johannesburg

South Jo'burg is home to the Apartheid Museum, a very moving and informative trip through South Africa's turbulent past and present.

The James Hall Museum of Transport is the largest museum dedicated to transport in South Africa.

Do

- **City Sightseeing** (<https://citysightseeing.co.za/en/joburg/open-top-bus-tours-joburg>), in the pedestrian mall at the "Zone Shopping center" in Oxford road, Rosebank (*next to Hamley's Toys with the main bus stop nearby*). Its red buses operate in Johannesburg. A very safe and convenient way to see the inner city. Hop-on hop-off city tour R299, plus Soweto tour R679. (updated Dec 2024 |)
- **Soweto** is a popular destination for travellers from around the world. Take a tour or drive in yourself using GPS set to Vilakazi Street: the road infrastructure and signs are excellent. You can stop off at Maponya Mall and join the Sowetan middle classes as they entertain themselves with retail and movies. A township tour that will take you around the densely populated but vibrant town. Use only official operators, and do not go on your own.
- **Gold Reef City** in South Johannesburg is an amusement park with a casino. The visitor can also learn about gold mining and go into a mine here.
- **Cricket:** Wanderers Stadium in Illovo near Sandton hosts international and domestic matches.
- **Golf:** the premier course is Glendower (<https://glendower.co.za/>) in Edenvale to the east. It often hosts the South African Open.



Parrots at the Montecasino bird gardens



Outdoor area at the Military History Museum



Apartheid Museum

Learn

- **1 University of the Witwatersrand (WITS)** (<http://www.wits.ac.za/>), Braamfontein, ☎ +27 11 717-1000, fax: +27 11 717-1065, studysa@international.wits.ac.za (<mailto:studysa@international.wits.ac.za>).
- **2 University of Johannesburg** (<http://www.uj.ac.za/>), Bunting Road, Auckland Park, ☎ +27 11 489-3129, fax: +27 11 489-2191, international@uj.ac.za (<mailto:international@uj.ac.za>).

Work

Due to South Africa's negotiated settlement which heralded the dawn of South Africa's democracy in 1994, South Africans have gained a reputation for holding meetings or *lekgotlas* (the Tswana word meaning "meeting place") to resolve their concerns, and plan for the future.

This desire to meet, discuss and strategise is also found among South Africa's business leaders, and Johannesburg as Africa and South Africa's economic hub is filled with conferencing venues and meeting places which can host a wide range of events for small or large groups.

Popular conference areas include the Rosebank and Sandton areas where conferences tend to be held in and around some of the city's top hotels. The Muldersdrift area and western region of Johannesburg has developed a reputation for outstanding function venues, particularly weddings and private events. While the midrand area located halfway between Johannesburg and Pretoria is also a popular conferencing and events area.

Buy

There are *many* craft markets in Johannesburg and the surrounding areas. You will also find plenty of beautifully crafted beadwork and wirework being sold on the roadside and at intersections. Though you will be able to bargain with the locals, give a thought to the crafters who are often unemployed and rely on sales to support themselves and their family.

Craftsmen and women from all over Africa sell their goods at the Rosebank flea market on Sundays and in a bazaar type shop in the Rosebank mall on week days. Johannesburg has no specific artwork, which you can't get in other parts of the country. But you will find very good quality shops for this. Don't forget to buy the 2 ft giraffe which you get all over and at the airport.

Shopping malls

Shopping malls are very popular in Johannesburg, due to their convenience, safety and the fact that there are few alternatives. Although, thankfully, Jozi is one of the few cities in the country that still has some street life. A typical shopping mall has all the usual chain stores (for clothes, books, music, chemists, etc.), a food hall (KFC, Mugg & Bean), and a big western-style supermarket in the basement. Many also have a multiplex cinema. They can be comfortable but soulless refuges that can trap the tourist with their familiar, air conditioned surrounds, so beware. There are many shopping malls throughout Johannesburg. Most have free secure parking, although you have to pay for parking in the more popular malls (Rosebank & Sandton).

You will also find many smaller shopping malls close to residential areas. Usually with one or two of the larger retail stores, a number of smaller chain stores, fast food and possibly a restaurant or coffee shop.

Eat

Johannesburg has a wide variety of places to eat and you'll be sure to find something to suit your taste buds, be it local delicacies or international cuisines. In addition to standard South African shopping mall restaurants Johannesburg is one of the few cities with various 'restaurant streets' scattered around the suburbs offering a more European dining experience.

Restaurant streets

- **7th Street, Melville** - Traditionally Melville has been where most people head to for an evening meal - however, it now caters to students more than the moneyed middle classes. Melville offers a small pocket of culture, with street vendors often selling their own artworks, and charity shops abound.
- **Gleneagles Road, Greenside** makes a good destination (north of Melville - head to where the M71 crosses the M20, Green Way) and there is a good collection of cafes and restaurants which won't be full of tourists.
- **Grant Avenue, Norwood** is becoming more popular since Melville started catering more to students. A collection of uncomplicated restaurants, including numerous sushi places and simple pizza and pasta Italian restaurants. Pick of the crop is probably Sharwama, with serves South African flavored Lebanese food, and also serves good steak and fish.
- **Tyrone Avenue, Parkview** has a collection of coffee shops and restaurants
- **4th Avenue, Parkhurst** boosts a handful of restaurants and shops along the street. The area is very safe so you can walk the street without any problems.
- **Queen's Street, Kensington** to the east of the CBD has a handful of restaurants near the crossing with Northumberland.
- **Derrick Avenue, Cyrildene** near Eastgate is a local Chinatown, and has numerous excellent Asian restaurants.

Don't ignore the CBD either, there are a handful of nice restaurants near the Market Theatre, and they are cheaper than their northern suburb cousins. Of course the northern suburb shopping malls are brimming with South African chain restaurants, of which the more expensive ones are also quite good, if a little soulless. South African cuisine features many varieties of sauces, and your food may be drowned in said sauce if you don't ask for it on the side

- **Melville** is neighbourhood where you can find many bars and mediocre restaurants. It is close to the national broadcaster (SABC) headquarters, all the universities and many artists, academics and students live in this community.
- **Fordsburg** has many Indian restaurants with authentic Indian cuisine as well as conventional franchise stores (Wimpy, Nandos, Fishmonger, Nescafe, etc.). Fordsburg is close to the Oriental Plaza and can be combined with your shopping expedition. Fordsburg is one of the few (if any) areas of Johannesburg that has a thriving outdoor street market and pedestrian traffic at night, in a relative sense. It's a small area and pedestrian traffic is light, but at least present. The area is more busy on Friday, Saturday and Sunday nights.

Drink

Good pubs and clubs are available in the **Melville student district**, Braamfontein, Rosebank and the Newtown cultural precinct. Posh and upmarket clubbing happens in the **Rivonia** and Sandton area.

Sleep

Sandton and the northern suburbs offer a wide range of accommodation.

For accommodations near O.R. Tambo International Airport, see the sleep sections for Kempton Park and Benoni.

Stay safe

Johannesburg has stubbornly high crime levels. Armed security guards (not necessarily the police) are a common sight in the city. Ask local people, such as your hotel staff, on what to do and when to do it.

Johannesburg earned its lawless reputation during the 1980s when the apartheid regime was collapsing. However things have improved enormously since those days with in large part all communities residing peacefully and in unity, although the advice you may receive from some Johannesburg residents may not match today's reality. Nevertheless you should keep security in mind and tourists must remain alert at all times when in unfamiliar surroundings.

When on the street (this doesn't apply to shopping malls and other secure environments) best general advice is to try your best to look like a local and to avoid displaying any form of wealth. Keep your cellphone hidden, leave your jewellery at the hotel and avoid carrying backpacks, daypacks, cameras or purses. Use a cheap plastic bag, keep your valuables at the hotel and take only the amount of money that you really need. Never use a purse, but put loose coins or notes in your pockets. Limit the credit and debit cards you carry to ones with low limits/balances and set appropriate withdrawal limits in case you are robbed at gunpoint at ATMs. Be mindful of your shoes - you may be able to dress down, but if you only have a new pair of sneakers, don't be surprised if you're still a target.

Should you be a victim of robbery, it is best to cooperate with your assailants, surrender your valuables, do not attempt to negotiate, do not look them in the eye. More importantly, do **not** resist, as the assailants may be armed. You should then report the robbery to the police immediately.

Above all, use your common sense! If someone insists that you follow them to get somewhere or do something, approach with extreme caution. Don't pay someone for something unless you have the goods in hand. When approached by beggars, it is generally a good idea to politely but firmly deny them.

Finally, keep things in perspective. Johannesburg has a partly-deserved bad reputation for crime, but most victims are local residents living in the townships. The overwhelming majority of visitors have a trouble-free stay.

Shopping malls

Shopping malls in Johannesburg are as safe as shopping malls anywhere else in the world, with pick-pocketing being the only risk, though a small one.

Central Business District

The central business district is busy during the day, and parts of it are pretty scruffy, but there are lots of police and private security around. The area is largely deserted at night, during weekends, and on holidays. There are many interesting things to do in the CBD; just plan where you are going to park and what you are going to visit beforehand, and never wander around aimlessly.

Northern suburbs

Walking and cycling in the Northern Suburbs is popular for both the residents and workers there, so you should be fine walking from your guesthouse to a local restaurant or shopping mall; however, distances can be large, which makes driving or taking a taxi better options. If you want to go jogging (not recommended for lone women) or for a long walk then carry a map and as few valuables as possible, and make sure you are home before it gets dark.

Townships

Alexandra is a very poor and dangerous township that deserves particular attention for the foreign visitor because it is next to the road that you would drive on from the airport to Sandton and is therefore easy to land up in if you get lost or take the wrong off-ramp.

Never take the London Road off-ramp from the N3 highway to get to Sandton, (which you will see on the horizon and London Road may look like a shortcut even when reading a map or using GPS) unless you are travelling with a local who knows where they are going, as this road goes right through the heart of Alexandra and you could easily get lost.

To get to Sandton when coming from the airport, take **Marlboro Drive** from the N3 and drive straight until you reach the M1 highway (this is also called the Marlboro offramp). Do not turn south/left (if you are coming from the N3) or right/south (if you are coming from the M1/Sandton side) anywhere between the N3 and the M1, including Louis Botha Avenue (which may be dangerous unless you know the area).

Alternatively, if you want to avoid the risk of getting this wrong, you can drive a bit further (the N3 becomes the N1) and take **Rivonia Road** to the south, which will take you straight into central Sandton passing through only affluent areas for the entire length of this road, so if you go the wrong way, you are still in safe areas.

Also, when taking the Gautrain (very safe and nauseatingly well-guarded) between central Sandton and the airport, one of the stations it will stop at is **Marlboro Station**. This station is the interchange to Pretoria and is right on the edge of Alexandra. *Do not* exit at this station.

Other townships surround the city and don't offer much for the tourist except for Soweto, the middle class parts of which (Orlando West) can be visited independently, although most choose to go with a tour.

Night-time

It is prudent to plan night-time journeys and to use a reputable taxi. If you must walk at night, make sure to remain in populated, well-lit areas, and walk confidently with a purpose so that you at least pretend that you know where you are going. Avoid giving the impression that you are lost, and ask directions only from shops and not random people on the streets.

Driving

It is best to use a GPS when driving so that you do not get lost. Also be aware that more South Africans die from road accidents than from violence. There is a great deal of aggression on the roads, and many accidents are fuelled by alcohol.

Do not leave any valuables on the seats as it is possible that your window could be smashed and your belongings grabbed. At night, do not stop at red traffic lights if you see people lingering there, as they may be up to no good. Slow down and go through the red traffic lights, even if you have to pay a fine (very small chance).

The risk of being hijacked is high in the Gauteng province, and therefore you need to be vigilant at all times. Watch out for vehicles following you or road blocks (stones, wood) on the roads. Keep in mind that most hijackings occur when the driver waits at a gate (usually at home), try to minimize that time by opening the gate (electronically) while still driving slowly towards it. If there is traffic behind, pull a side and let them pass first. If you have parked in a quiet area, be particularly careful when you go to and from your car as thieves can wait for victims to exit/enter their vehicle. If you are faced with a suspicious or dangerous encounter, drive to the nearest police station or well-lit populated area.

Public transport

The Gautrain is totally safe and provides frequent rides from Park Station stopping in Rosebank, Sandton, Marlboro, Midrand, Centurion, Pretoria and Hatfield. From the station, Uber is accessible to reach other destinations in the different neighbourhoods. The new Rea Vaya buses are too a viable, safe and cheap option unlike the city's Metrobus service that can be safe to ride although it is often late and far too unreliable and confusing for a short-term foreign visitor to figure out.

Women

Rape and sexual assault levels are exceptionally high. However, most sexual assault and rape cases involve alcohol and take place between people who know each other. Care should be taken in sexual encounters due to the high HIV levels in Johannesburg; insist on using condoms.

Females should always avoid walking alone and should try, if possible, to remain in groups.

Stay healthy

Tap water is completely safe to drink, Johannesburg's water has one of the highest ratings in the world.

There is a Travel Clinic at OR Tambo International Airport

- **Kloof Road Travel Clinic**, 17 Kloof Rd, ☎ +27 11 616-4400, fax: +27 11 616-3757. Corner Arterial Rd W Bedfordview, Dr DM Smith / Sr C Standford,
- **Airport Clinic & Travel Vaccination Centre**, Ground Floor, New Domestic Arrivals Terminal, ☎ +27 11 921-6609. GP, dentist, vaccinations and malaria prophylaxis

Hospitals

It is best to avoid public hospitals as standards have declined, but private hospitals are of world class standard.

The following hospitals cater for 24-hour accident and emergency treatment:

- **Sunninghill Hospital**, Cnr Witkoppen & Nanyuki Rds, Sunninghill, ☎ +27 11 806-1500.
- **Milpark Hospital**, 9 Guild Rd, Parktown West, ☎ +27 11 480-5600.
- **Netcare Garden City Hospital**, 35 Bartlett Rd, Mayfair West, Johannesburg, 2092. +27 11 495 5000
- **Life Flora Hospital**, William Nicol St, Florida Park, Roodepoort, 1709. +27 11 470 7777
- **Life Brenthurst Clinic**, 4 Park Ln, Parktown, Johannesburg, 2193. +27 11 647 9000
- **Clinix Lesedi Private Hospital**, 7948 Chris Hani Road, Diepkloof Zone 6, Diepkloof, 1862. +27 11 933 5001
- Helen Joseph Hospital +27 11 489 1011
- Coronation Hospital for women and children; +27 11 470-9000
- Chris Hani Baragwanath Academic Hospital, 26 Chris Hani Rd, Diepkloof 319-lq, Johannesburg, 1864. +27 11 933 8000

Connect

Wi-Fi

Always-On (<http://www.alwayson.co.za>), +27 11 575-2505, provides prepaid Wi-Fi access in a number of locations in and around Johannesburg. Simply connect to the access point and you will be given the opportunity to pay for access by credit card. Pricing starts at around R15 for 10 minutes or R60 for 100MB.

Coverage areas include:

- **City Lodge**. Most of them.
- **The Baron**. Bryanston and Woodmead.
- **Mugg&Bean**. Just about all of them.

- **McDonald's.** All of them.
- **Nand.** Benmore, Chilli Lane, Douglasdale, Rivonia.
- **OR Tambo Airport.** Most of the airport is covered as well as the City Lodge and Airport Sun InterContinental.
- **Protea Balalaika Hotel.**
- **Wimpy.** Midrand, Randburg, Centurion, Aero Centre
- **Highland View Executive Guesthouse,** 164 Highland Road, Kensington.

Cope

Consulates

Operating hours differ for each consulate; call prior to visiting.

-  **China** (<http://johannesburg.china-consulate.gov.cn>), 25 Cleveland Rd, Sandhurst, Sandton, ☎ +27 11 784-7241, fax: +27 11 883-5274, chinaconsul_jb_za@mfa.gov.cn (mailto:chinaconsul_jb_za@mfa.gov.cn).
-  **United Kingdom**, Dunkeld Corner 275 Jan Smuts Avenue, Dunkel West Johannesburg, ☎ +27 861 837-221.
- **U.S. Consulate General Johannesburg**, 1 Sandton Dr, Sandhurst, Johannesburg, 2146, ☎ +27 11 290 3000
-  **France** (<http://www.consulfrance-jhb.org>), 3rd floor, Standard Bank Building, 191 Jan Smuts Ave, Parktown North, Johannesburg, 2196, ☎ +27 11 778 5600.
- **Consulate General of Italy in Johannesburg**, 37 1st Ave (entrance on, 2nd St, Houghton Estate, Johannesburg, 2198, ☎ +27 11 728 1392
- **Consulate General of Portugal**, 15 Ernest Oppenheimer Ave, Bruma, Johannesburg, 2198> {{phone|+27 11 622 0645
- **Lesotho Consulate General**, 222 Smit St, Johannesburg, 2001
- **Argentine Consulate General**, Fredman Towers, 13 Fredman Dr, Sandton, Johannesburg, 2146, ☎ +27 11 783 9032
- **Consulate General of Greece**, 261 Oxford Rd, Illovo, Sandton, 2196, ☎ +27 11 214 2300
-  **Nigeria** (<https://johannesburg.foreignaffairs.gov.ng/>), 16, Rivonia Road, Illovo, Saxonwold 2132, ☎ +27 11 442 3620-2, info@foreignaffairs.gov.ng (mailto:info@foreignaffairs.gov.ng). M-F 08:30-16:30. (updated Aug 2024 |)

Go next

- **Pretoria** is only a short while away from Johannesburg and has a lot to offer visitors with historic architecture and a more laidback atmosphere than its bigger sister
- **Sun City** is a two-hour drive away and offers world class golf courses and entertainment. The **Pilanesberg Game Reserve** is adjacent to Sun City and offers visitors a taste of an African Game Reserve. However it is no comparison to the world famous Kruger Park which is about 350 km from Johannesburg.
- **Mpumalanga Escarpment in a weekend**
- **Rietvlei Nature Reserve** next to the R21 in Tshwane gives one the opportunity to forget about the city for a while.
- **Cradle of Humankind** is a World Heritage Site comprising a number of attractions including the Sterkfontein Caves, the Wonder Caves and [Maropeng](http://www.maropeng.co.za) (<http://www.maropeng.co.za>)

visitor education centre. Explore fossil-filled caves where important palaeoanthropologist discoveries such as Mrs Ples and Little Foot were found. +27 14 577-9000

- **Thaba Ya Batswana** (<http://www.tyb.co.za>) is a rare and valuable jewel surrounded by the southern Johannesburg metropolis, which captures the spirit of the African renaissance. It is situated in the Klipriversberg Nature Reserve area and has an abundance of indigenous trees, plants, birds and wildlife.
- **Gaborone** is the capital city of Botswana, has a very low crime rate but is much more relaxed than Johannesburg. It is just an hour away by plane and about five hours away by car. The drive there is quite scenic.
- **Limpopo** is a four hour drive from Johannesburg and has some of the most beautiful game reserves in South Africa.

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